

Explain an unfamiliar idea

Teaching guide

Help a listener understand a new term.

Understand the distinction

Start with a familiar category, then describe the defining feature and give a concrete example. A commuter is a person who regularly travels between home and work. The example should clarify the definition, not replace it.

Adjust the detail to the listener. Ask what they already know and check understanding with a useful question. Avoid explaining one unfamiliar word through several more unfamiliar words. An analogy helps only if you also state where it differs.

Compare the patterns

CATEGORY

A library is a place where people can borrow books.

Start with a familiar kind of thing.

EXAMPLE

You can borrow a novel and return it later.

Make the activity concrete.

CHECK

How is borrowing different from buying?

Ask about the important distinction.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Which opening is clearer for a beginner: A commuter is a person ... / A commuter is an intermodal participant ...?

2. Explain borrow in one simple sentence.

3. Why might an example alone be insufficient?

Use it in your own life

Explain a familiar service to someone who has never used it.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. A commuter is a person ...

A familiar category gives the listener a starting point.

2. Borrow means use something for a time and then return it.

Include the temporary use and expected return.

3. It may not show what all uses have in common.

A short definition gives the general meaning.

One possible response

A delivery locker is a secure place to collect a package. You use a code to open its door.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-42.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Explain a familiar service to someone who has never used it.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.